



Ralte rallies: Lalengmawia Ralte was adjudged the Player of the Match in the ISL final. FSDL/ISL MEDIA

contributions to Mumbai's win.

"We know how it feels when we're losing, but then we have two choices: to give up or keep pushing to get rewarded. This is my message for my team: believe and stick together because this is a powerful thing," Kratly explained.

Mohun Bagan's nightmare

Habas, the most successful head coach in the ISL, had faced Mumbai City in the 2020-21 final, with Mumbai winning 2-1.

Before the 2023-24 final, he had talked about completing a circle, trying to beat the Islanders in what could be his 'last phase of coaching'.

In the match, however, nothing clicked for Mohun Bagan. Petratos was relatively quiet (he had only one shot in the game), and Manvir's progressive passes were limited, with him creating only one chance.

Habas, after the loss, pointed out

fatigue and the suspension of forward Armando Sadiku as possible reasons for the loss.

"Maybe, we've played too many finals to win this match," Habas said.

Sadiku, having joined Mohun Bagan last summer, had 11 goals and an assist in all competitions but remained suspended in the final for breaching the All India Football Federation Code of Conduct. A physically imposing forward, Sadiku's exploits in breaking the press could have been a panacea to Mohun Bagan's misery, according to the Spaniard.

"I think Armando is more aggressive than Jason (Cummings) or Dimi (Dimitri Petratos). That allows good possibility (space) for other guys to play. In football, we can't change history," Habas conceded.

Kolkata derby sub-plot

Football in Kolkata barely extends beyond the gamut of East Bengal and Mohun Bagan, the biggest clubs in the city. The ISL final was no different, and when the Islanders won against a familiar rival, they



GOLDEN BOOT

Dimitrios Diamantakos (Kerala Blasters)

GOLDEN GLOVE

Phurba Lachenpa (Mumbai City FC)

EMERGING PLAYER OF THE LEAGUE

Vikram Partap Singh (Mumbai City FC)

GOLDEN BALL

Dimitri Petratos (Mohun Bagan Super Giant)

WINNER PRIZE MONEY

Mumbai City FC (Rs. 6 crore)

RUNNER-UP PRIZE MONEY

Mohun Bagan Super Giant (Rs. 2.5 crore)

BEST PITCH

Jamshedpur FC

GRASSROOTS AWARD

FC Goa

BEST ELITE YOUTH PROGRAMME

Bengaluru FC

found a friend in East Bengal.

In fact, the player who captained Mumbai to victory is also a former East Bengal player, Rahul Bheke.

So is Mehtab Singh, who celebrated the win with Jamuna Das, better known as Lozenge Mashi, an ardent East Bengal fan who had come in Mumbai's colours — blue and white — at the Salt Lake Stadium.

After the match, two members of East Bengal also greeted Bheke with sweets, celebrating the victory.

The 10th season of the ISL saw the highest number of teams in the league's history so far and delivered some mouth-watering clashes over 139 matches, including the rise of some Indian youngsters like Vikram, Jay Gupta, and Abhishek Suryavanshi. That Mumbai City, which won the title, had over 55 per cent of its goals scored by Indians augurs well for the future of the sport in the country.